

Dendroaspis angusticeps

East African green mamba

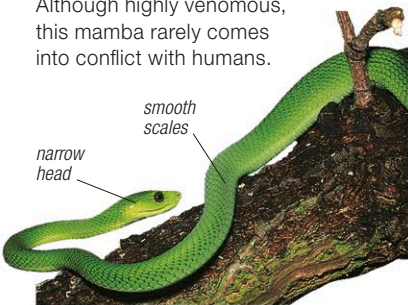


Length 5–8¼ ft (1.5–2.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Not evaluated

Location E. and S.E. Africa



The bright green color, slender shape, and long tail of the East African green mamba are all features that are ideally suited to an animal living in trees. Alert and fast moving, this snake chases its prey through the canopy and, if disturbed, it usually moves swiftly to higher branches or passes from the branches of one tree to another; if cornered, it will turn and strike. Although highly venomous, this mamba rarely comes into conflict with humans.



Dendroaspis polylepis

Black mamba



Length 8¼–11 ft (2.5–3.5 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location E. and southern Africa



In addition to being one of the most poisonous snakes, the black mamba is probably the fastest, making it one of the world's most dangerous predators. In short bursts, it can reach 12½ mph (20kph), which is fast enough to overtake someone moving at a brisk run. The black mamba is not actually black, but gray or brown, with a streamlined body covered with large, smooth scales. Highly territorial, it makes its home den in a rock crevice or a hollow tree. It is active during the day, and feeds on birds and small mammals. Females lay 12–17 eggs in chambers underground. The venom of the black mamba is very fast-acting, and bites are often fatal if not treated quickly.

OCCASIONAL CLIMBER

This primarily ground-living snake, mostly found in open woodland, may also occasionally climb. Despite its size, it is highly agile, effortlessly sliding through thorn bushes and trees.

FIGHTING FOR A MATE

During the breeding season, male black mambas fight by raising and intertwining the front half of their bodies, with each snake trying to force its opponent to the ground. However, the fight is ritualized and does not involve any serious harm. Following this test of strength, the winner mates with any females in his territory.



Laticauda colubrina

Yellow-lipped sea krait



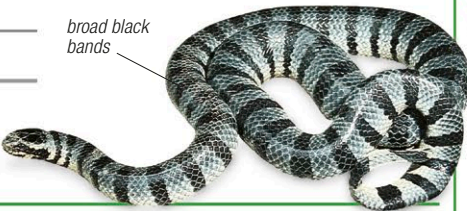
Length 3¼–6½ ft (1–2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Least concern

Location S. and S.E. Asia



The bluish gray, yellow-lipped sea krait is one of about 40 species of snakes that have flattened,

paddle-shaped tails and live and feed at sea. It is found in coastal waters, mangrove swamps, and coral reefs, where it hunts fishes—particularly eels. Like all sea snakes, it is highly poisonous, but poses no threat to humans since it does not bite. Most sea snakes spend their entire lives at sea, and give birth to live young, but the yellow-lipped sea krait and its relatives come ashore to lay their eggs under leaf litter.



Micrurus lemniscatus

South American coral snake



Length 23½–35 in (60–90 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiburrowing
Status Least concern

Location N. and C. South America



This brilliantly colored reptile is one of about 40 species of coral snakes that occur in warm parts of the Americas.

Each species has a characteristic pattern of contrasting bands, warning predators that they are poisonous. However, because coral snakes have a semiburrowing lifestyle, generally emerging only at night, their colors are often concealed. Coral snakes feed on small lizards and snakes. They have highly toxic venom, but human fatalities are rare.



Naja naja

Indian cobra



Length 4–5½ ft (1.2–1.7 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S. Asia



Renowned for its use in snake charming, this animal is one of the most dangerous snakes in India. It is responsible for a relatively small but nonetheless significant proportion of snake-bite mortalities, which total 50,000 per year in India alone. This is partly due to its preference for rice paddies and roadside banks, which are often close to villages and so bring it into contact with humans. Indian cobras are very variable in color, ranging from brown to black, but most individuals have distinctive, pale “spectacle” markings on the back of the hood. As with other cobras, the hood is spread out when the snake feels threatened, but is folded away at other times. Although Indian cobras are sometimes seen basking in the sun, they are most active at night, and are good climbers and swimmers. They feed on small mammals, birds, lizards, and other snakes, killing them within seconds with

their potent neurotoxic venom. The principal predators of Indian cobras, other than humans, are carnivorous mammals—notably mongooses—and birds of prey.

